

OPPOSITIONAL IDENTITY AND BACK-VOWEL FRONTING IN A TRIETHNIC CONTEXT: THE CASE OF LUMBEE ENGLISH

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ABSTRACT: This study considers the dynamic trajectory of fronting of the back vowels *BOOT* and *BOAT* for 27 speakers in a unique, longstanding context of a substantive, triethnic contact situation involving American Indians, European Americans, and African Americans over three disparate generations in Robeson County, North Carolina. The results indicate that the earlier status of Lumbee English fronting united them with the African American vowel system, particularly for the *BOOT* vowel, but that more recent generations have shifted toward alignment with European American speakers. Given that the biracial Southeastern United States historically identified Lumbee Indians as “free persons of color” and the persistent skepticism about the Lumbee Indians as merely a mixed group of European Americans and African Americans, the movement away from the African American pattern toward the European American pattern was interpreted as a case of oppositional identity in which Lumbee Indians disassociate themselves from African American vowel norms in subtle but socially meaningful ways.

KEYWORDS: Lumbee language, African American Language, triethnic language contact, language accommodation, language change

ROBESON COUNTY, NORTH CAROLINA, is the unique site of a longstanding, substantive triethnic situation in which Lumbee Indians, African Americans, and European Americans have lived together for several centuries now. The Lumbee Indians are the largest Native American Indian group east of the Mississippi River, the largest nonreservation tribe in the United States, and arguably the most-debated group of Native American Indians in the United States in terms of their tribal status. More than 45,000 Lumbee Indians live in Robeson County in a relatively stable triethnic situation in which approximately 42.3% of the population is Lumbee Indian, 30.6% European American, and 23.6% African American (U.S. Census 2021).

Though historic census data are sometimes difficult to interpret given the fact that American Indians were classified as “free persons of color” through the nineteenth century, evidence indicates that Robeson County

has maintained a substantive population of European Americans, African Americans, and American Indians, at least since the American Revolutionary War. As noted in Lowery (2018, 44):

Lumbee founding families lived in a place of twelve or fifteen square miles that had no known name besides what they themselves called it, “the Settlement.” [...] The Settlement held somewhat less than 10 percent of the population of the county. Exact numbers are hard to come by, because public officials labeled Indians “free persons of color,” a designation that included free blacks as well. Enslaved people, on the other hand, made up about 30 percent of the county population, and European settlers the remaining 50 percent—a significant number but not enough to take complete control.

Though the proportion of American Indians, African Americans, and European Americans has varied over the years, there is evidence that substantive numbers of these three groups have cohabited Robeson County for several centuries now, making it one of the most robust cases among sustained triethnic situations in the Southeastern United States involving American Indians.

Over the past couple of decades, linguists at North Carolina State University have described a number of the distinctive morphosyntactic traits of the vernacular variety of English associated with the Lumbee Indians, including the use of perfective *be* (e.g., *I’m been there*) (Wolfram 1996; Dannenberg 2002), finite *be* (e.g., *that’s how it bes*) (Dannenberg and Wolfram 1998), and null copula (e.g., *you nice*) (Dannenberg 1999); the remorphologization of past-tense *be* (e.g., *I weren’t there* vs. *I was there*) (Wolfram and Sellers 1999); and some of the structural traits of its vowel system (Thomas 2001). Other analyses have contextualized the symbolic cultural significance of the variety of English correlated with the indigenous status of Lumbees in Robeson County (e.g., Wolfram et al. 2002; Coggs shall 2008; Wolfram, Daugherty, and Cullinan 2014; Wolfram 2018).

This article examines the language change trajectory over time and ethnicity for a single, relatively nonsalient vowel feature to provide a complementary perspective on the dynamics of language change in Lumbee English vis-à-vis African American and European American English in Robeson County, namely, the fronting of the back vowels BOAT and BOOT. Fronting of the BOOT and BOAT vowels is a relatively well-established feature of the Southern Vowel Shift, displayed by European American speakers (e.g., Labov 1991; Thomas 2001; Labov, Ash, and Boberg 2006); at the same time, the fronting of back vowels is NOT a trait associated with the African American Southern vowel system (Thomas 2007; Kohn 2013; King 2016; Jones 2020). In fact, the absence of fronting is one of the distinguishing traits of the African American Language (AAL) vowel system in the South.

Back-vowel fronting is a feature that has been correlated with ethnic or identity traits of speakers in other communities, including Latinx (Fought 1999) and Asian (Hall-Lew 2010; Wong 2014) communities as well as in regional varieties, such as Pittsburghese (Eberhardt 2009) and other varieties of European American and African American English distributed throughout the South (Fridland 2012). Nonetheless, it is not a trait frequently discussed in popular culture and is rarely if ever a topic of public commentary when discussing Southern or African American vowel systems. Its status as a social indicator (Labov 1966; Wolfram and Schilling 2016, 164) therefore contrasts with the kinds of morphosyntactic social markers and stereotyped features mentioned above as well as other Southern vowel traits, such as ungliding of the diphthongal /aɪ/ of BIDE, a salient feature of Southern English (Bailey et al. 1991; Plichta and Preston 2005). In this respect, we consider back-vowel fronting to be a low-saliency feature, unlike some of the more well-known and recognized traits of Lumbee Vernacular English we have described in previous research. Accordingly, a study of change in this type of trait over time can add complementary insight into some of the more subtle aspects of accommodation and divergence that distinguish and unite Lumbee English with respect to its cohort ethnic language varieties in Robeson County.

THE STATUS OF THE LUMBEE IN ROBESON COUNTY

For as long as they have existed in Robeson County, the Lumbee Indians have considered themselves to be distinct from the European and African American settlers in the area. As Lowery (2018) observes in her comprehensive description of their situational history, the Lumbee show coexisting systems of kinship and place that provide ways of situating them and “making sense in the world” (xv). She observes:

Knowledge of kinship (the relationships between different families) and place (the stories told about families in certain locations) is critical to Lumbee identity. A person is Lumbee if two criteria are met: one has ancestors who are members of this long-standing community with its distinct history, and one’s family still identifies with the community and specific places within it.

When one Lumbee meets another, two questions reveal everything they each need to know about the other’s identity: “Who’s your people?” and “Where do they stay at?” The first is a way to establish kinship connection and to understand where in the tribe’s social life a person fits. [...] “Where you stay at?” situates someone in relation to the Lumbee homeland. [6]

The Lumbee’s association of kinship and homeland is, of course, quite different from that of the African Americans and European Americans who

cohabit the region. The Lumbee consider it their homeland in a way that binds them sociohistorically and culturally to the territory where they are the majority of the population. One prominent Lumbee offered the following observation about the Indian identity of the famous actress Heather Locklear, whose paternal grandparent was a Lumbee Indian, in our documentary *Indian by Birth: The Lumbee Dialect* (Hutcheson 2001):

If you maintain your community ties and stuff— if it's just coming home for Christmas and for Mother's Day and, and Lumbee Homecoming and stuff like that, it's got to be something, some kind of way, I mean, you know. This Heather Locklear thing— Heather Locklear ain't no Lum. I don't care what nobody says. I don't care if her granddaddy, great-granddaddy, or what, what came from here. She's never lived as a Lum. She's never been involved in this community; she's never certainly had to experience the things that are just gonna be a part of your life experience if you're a Lum and, you know, you live in Robeson County. So it's hard for me to see someone like that as a Lum. To me, it's got to be— you just got to be a part of this community even if it is from a distance. So, I guess what I'm saying you got to have the genetics and the culture. [Karl A. Hunt, 16:42 (■)]

This kind of association with the physical place of Robeson County is unique to the Lumbee in Robeson County. Whites and Blacks live there but have no attachment to the county as a place uniquely associated with their culture and identity (Wolfram 2018, 353). At the same time, the Lumbee are also different from other American Indian groups that are recognized as Indian tribes by the federal government. For example, the Cherokee Indians, a federally recognized group of Indians located in the western mountains of North Carolina and Oklahoma, have a treaty with the U.S. government, an official tribal roll used to establish recognition, and an indigenous American Indian language that is still used by some members of the community. The Lumbee have a loose, self-reported basis of genealogy related to kinship, have no treaty with the federal government, and have no remnant of a unitary ancestral language.

The quest for federal recognition by the Lumbee has been a long, arduous journey, starting in the 1880s and continuing to the present. In 1885, the North Carolina General Assembly recognized the Indians of Robeson County as Croatan, an American Indian tribe associated with the Lost Colony. Just a few years later, in 1888, the Lumbee petitioned the U.S. government for recognition and assistance. They were denied federal recognition by the Bureau of Indian Affairs due to a lack of funding, which was the start of a long, continuous trail of failed petitions for federal recognition. Finally, in 1956, they were officially recognized by a Congressional Act that ironically managed yet again to underscore their marginal status. An Act Relating to

the Lumbee Indians of North Carolina (1956) recognized the Lumbee as having American Indian origins and designated them as the Lumbee Indians of North Carolina, but stipulated, “Nothing in this Act shall make such Indians eligible for any services performed by the United States for Indians because of their status as Indians” (255). Since that time, new petitions for full recognition have been submitted routinely, and there is currently yet another petition to gain full recognition under consideration as this article goes to press, passed by the House of Representatives in November 2020 and currently in the Senate’s Committee for Indian Affairs (Lumbee Recognition Act 2020). There are a number of components to the Lumbee struggle for federal recognition, but a primary one is directly related to their historical language situation, as they relinquished their ancestral language(s) generations ago.

If the Lumbee had a heritage language that was still used or identified specifically, their argument for full federal recognition would have almost certainly been settled in their favor a long time ago (Wolfram et al. 2002). The historical circumstances surrounding the Lumbee, however, make it difficult even to trace the roots of their indigenous, ancestral language. Little documentation of the languages of the Lumber River region exists, and linguists are uncertain about what language or languages the Lumbee spoke in the past. By the mid-1700s, the Lumbee apparently were no longer reliant exclusively on their ancestral language for communication, at least in their interactions with outsiders, which would have masked their ancestral language roots. An additional problem comes from the cultural dynamics of the area. According to archeological and linguistic evidence, the Lumber River region was a zone of cultural interaction for different American Indian language families, so it is quite possible that the Lumbee community developed not from a single, unitary cultural group but from a conglomerate of American Indians who spoke different languages. Though the Lumbee lost their ancestral language generations ago, they have developed a variety of English that is ethnolinguistically distinctive, as described in a number of descriptive studies by researchers from the Language and Life Project at North Carolina State University (Wolfram and Dannenberg 1999; Dannenberg 2002; Wolfram et al. 2002).

To examine the extent to which the English of Lumbee speakers is identifiable to listeners, Hammonds (1999) designed a simple identification task. Twelve anonymous passages of 20–30 seconds each were taken from the conversational interviews conducted by the staff of the North Carolina Language and Life Project; four from each of the major Robeson County ethnic groups: Lumbee, White, and Black. The vernacular dialect samples, which were neutral with respect to cultural content, included two men and

two women from each group, one older and one younger speaker. Listeners were asked simply to identify if each speaker was Lumbee, White, or Black. The task was then administered to two different groups of speakers, one to lifetime residents of Robeson County and one to listeners from Raleigh, North Carolina, located about 100 miles north of Robeson County. Participants from Raleigh generally know who the Lumbee are but do not generally have regular contact with them. The results of identification task are given in table 1 (reprinted from Wolfram 2018, 351, although they originally appeared in Hammonds 1999).

The results from table 1 indicate a significant difference in the ability of the two groups of listeners to identify groups, but only with respect to the Lumbee Indians. Residents of Robeson County, where the Lumbee live, accurately identify Lumbee speakers 81% of the time, showing a local, tripartite ethnic differentiation, whereas residents of the outside Raleigh community only indicate a bipartite ethnic perceptual differentiation; they can accurately identify African American from non-African American speakers but not Lumbee from non-Lumbee. Importantly, in more than 80% of the misidentifications, listeners misidentified Lumbee as European American rather than African American (Hammonds 1999). The Lumbee ability to identify community members thus supports the claim offered by a 35-year-old Lumbee artist interviewed in Hutcheson (2001):

That's [i.e., the dialect] how we recognize who we are, you know, not only by looking at someone, we know that's who we are by our language. You recognize someone who's from Spain because they speak Spanish or from France because they speak French, I said, and that's how we recognize Lumbee. If we're anywhere in the country and hear ourselves speak, we know exactly who we are. [Hayes Alan Locklear, 10:32 (🔊)]

Part of the strong sense of dialect identity among the Lumbee may be related to the role that self-definition has played in their cultural identity. Outsiders have often expressed skepticism about the status of the Lumbee as "real Indians" due to their early departure from traditional American

TABLE 1
Results from Speaker Identification Task for Lumbee, White,
and African American Speakers in Robeson County, North Carolina

<i>Regional Listening Group</i>	<i>Correct Speaker Identification</i>		
	<i>Lumbee</i>	<i>European American</i>	<i>African American</i>
Robeson County (<i>n</i> = 41)	81%	74%	80%
Raleigh, N.C. (<i>n</i> = 37)	38%	80%	91%
Statistical significance	$\chi^2 = 57.0$; $p < .001$	$\chi^2 = 1.6$; $p = \text{n.s.}$	$\chi^2 = 1.2$; $p = \text{n.s.}$

Indian customs and the early loss of an ancestral language. The response to this skepticism by Lumbees has been to emphasize the role of self-definition in their identity. One of the participants in our study noted, “We know who we are, you know. We know, we have always known. Y’all are the ones who are always trying to identify something” (Karl A. Hunt; Hutcheson 2001, 4:55 [audio]). Such self-asserted identity embraces community-based dialect distinctiveness, and considerable cultural capital may be vested in the unique vernacular variety of English. For the Lumbee, proximity to the physical and social place of Robeson County serves as a defining characteristic of group membership, along with their kinship status with other Indian families in the community. As noted in Wolfram, Daugherty, and Cullinan (2014), tribal status is linked to Robeson County in terms of traditional community activity (de facto segregation of schools, churches, social activity, cultural events, etc.). In this context, membership on the tribal rolls is secondary to self-identification related to place and space. As noted, the Lumbee have no reservation land and their federal recognition is without entitlements. At the same time, their identity is strongly associated with the arbitrary boundary of a county within North Carolina and kinship associations. In this context, their language identity is indexed by a unique English variety, which serves a central role in supporting their identity as Indian. This linguistic identity is explicitly acknowledged in the 1956 congressional act that recognized the Lumbee, which states:

Whereas by reason of tribal legend, coupled with a distinctive appearance and MANNER OF SPEECH [...] shall, from and after the ratification of this Act, be known and designated as Lumbee Indians of North Carolina. [An Act Relating to the Lumbee Indians of North Carolina 1956, 256; emphasis added]

From such statements incorporated into the congressional act of recognition and the personal references to their unique speech by many of the participants in our study, it is clear that the dialect of English used by the Lumbee is connected to their identity. But how does that situate them in terms of their dialect relationship to cohort European Americans and African Americans in the context of their everyday lives and interactions?

THE STATUS OF BACK-VOWEL FRONTING IN LUMBEE ENGLISH

To examine the role of back-vowel fronting across time in three different ethnic groups, three different age groups were identified: (1) those born in 1915–35, representing the oldest group, born before World War II; (2)

speakers born in 1936–55, during the expansion of Robeson County surrounding World War II; and (3) speakers born in 1956–80, a period covering the official integration in the schools. World War II was a distinctive era for the Lumbee, as many Lumbees joined the armed forces and served in the war, expanding their interactional contacts with the world beyond Robeson County and southeast North Carolina. The Lumbee treasure their veterans and regularly celebrate them during festivities such as Pow Wows, Homecoming (July 4), and other cultural events (Lowery 2018). This period opened up a new era of interpersonal interaction with those outside of their community.

The data analyzed here were obtained from the Sociolinguistic Archive and Analysis Project (Kendall 2007), where the data from Wolfram et al.'s (2002) original sociolinguistic interviews, collected from 1993 to 2000, are stored.

We analyze BOOT and BOAT vowels from 27 speakers in this corpus: 3 speakers (two women and one man) per age group per ethnic group. Prelateral tokens are excluded from these measurements, as many scholars have previously reported that following laterals inhibit fronting (Labov, Ash, and Boberg 2006, 143–44, 152–57; Fridland and Bartlett 2006). The data were hand-transcribed and then force-aligned with the P2FA forced aligner (Yuan and Liberman 2008). Then, we extracted F1 and F2 acoustic measurements at vowel nuclei (25% segmental duration) using a Praat script. It is worth noting that we extracted acoustic measurements for all English vowel classes for each speaker to facilitate Lobanov normalization (Lobanov 1971) using the online NORM suite resource (Thomas and Kendall 2007). This normalization protocol helped to minimize the effects of differences in vocal tract size among speakers in our data.

Figures 1 and 2 show mean normalized F2 values by ethnicity and generation for /o/ and /u/ productions, respectively. In both figures, longer bars represent fronter nuclei. Both plots suggest complex patterns of fronting behaviors, with considerable variability both within and across ethnicities and generations. Next, we turn to a series of statistical analyses to determine which of these differences are significant.

We conducted a series of statistical analyses to determine how ethnicity and gender conditioned back vowel fronting by generation. We fit six mixed-effects linear regression models using the lme4 package (Bates et al. 2014) in conjunction with the lmerTest package (Kuznetsova, Brockhoff, and Christensen 2017) in R (R Core Team 2020), one for each vowel-generation pair. We divided the data up by generation for linear modeling due to two aggregated models (one for /o/ and one for /u/) with generation and ethnicity as fixed effects not converging when run with random by-speaker intercepts. To remedy this lack of convergence, we chose to divide the data further by

FIGURE 1
Means and Standard Errors for /o/ Nuclei Productions by Ethnicity and Generation

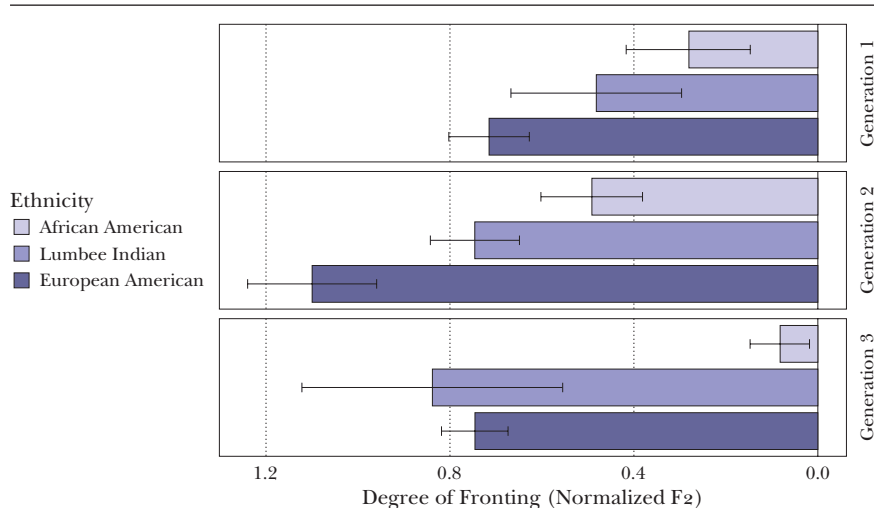
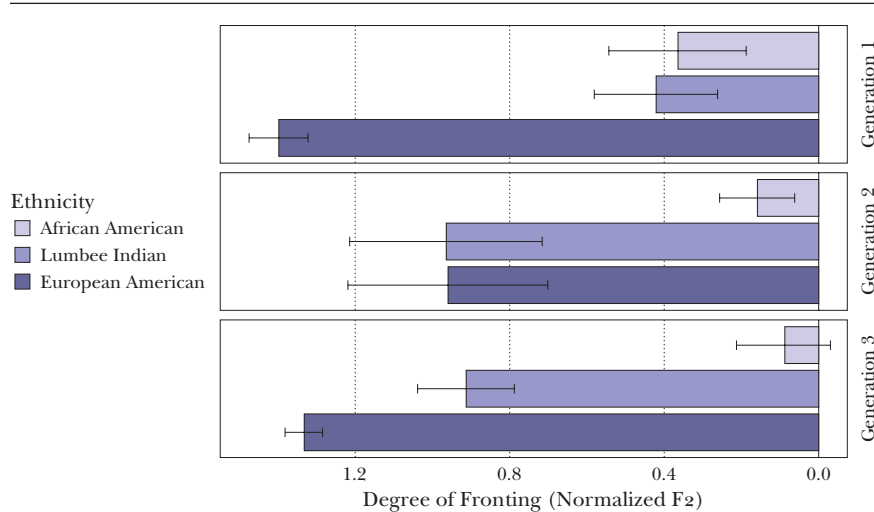


FIGURE 2
Means and Standard Errors for /u/ Nuclei Productions by Ethnicity and Generation



generation and had success fitting all six models for each vowel-generation pair in terms of convergence. The base models for each vowel-generation pair all contained fixed effects for ethnicity, with a reference level of African American, and gender, with a reference level of female, as well as random by-speaker intercepts. The best fit models for the BOAT vowel for each of the three generations, which contain significant effects of ethnicity but lack

TABLE 2
Best Fit Model for /o/ Productions by Generation
(with a reference level of African American)

	<i>Coefficient</i>	<i>Estimate</i>	<i>t-value</i>	<i>p-value</i>
Generation 1	Ethnicity: European American	0.433	1.704	.092
(b. 1915–35)	Ethnicity: Lumbee Indian	0.200	0.551	.583
Generation 2	Ethnicity: European American	0.664	4.543	<.001***
(b. 1936–55)	Ethnicity: Lumbee Indian	0.756	1.791	.075
Generation 3	Ethnicity: European American	0.608	3.533	.001***
(b. 1956–80)	Ethnicity: Lumbee Indian	0.254	0.827	.410

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

significant gender effects, are shown in table 2. Significant effects at the $\alpha = .05$ level are indicated with asterisks.

These results demonstrate that BOAT fronting was not significantly different across the three ethnic groups in Robeson County for the oldest generation but that in the two later generations European American speakers produced significantly fronter BOAT tokens than African American speakers. Additionally, the models show that Lumbee Indian speakers did not produce significantly fronter BOAT tokens than African American speakers in any generational category. Overall, these findings suggest that BOAT fronting is a change happening primarily among European American speakers in Robeson County.

The best fit models for BOOT productions across the three generations are shown in table 3, and these models mirror the best fit models for BOOT productions in that they contain significant effects of ethnicity but do not contain significant gender effects. Significant effects at the $\alpha = 0.05$ level are again indicated with asterisks.

TABLE 3
Best Fit Model for /u/ Productions by Generation
(with a reference level of African American)

	<i>Coefficient</i>	<i>Estimate</i>	<i>t-value</i>	<i>p-value</i>
Generation 1	Ethnicity: European American	1.290	4.375	<.001***
(b. 1915–35)	Ethnicity: Lumbee Indian	0.070	0.186	.853
Generation 2	Ethnicity: European American	1.550	7.392	<.001***
(b. 1936–55)	Ethnicity: Lumbee Indian	1.026	3.123	.002**
Generation 3	Ethnicity: European American	0.999	3.466	.001***
(b. 1956–80)	Ethnicity: Lumbee Indian	1.005	2.722	.009**

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

These findings show that BOOT fronting is a change that has occurred across multiple ethnic groups at different rates: European American speakers produced significantly fronter BOOT tokens than African American speakers across all three generations, while Lumbee Indian speakers only started producing significantly fronter BOOT tokens than African American speakers starting in the middle generation. Additionally, the cross-group timing differences in the adoption of fronted /u/ tokens suggests that the diffusion of this change in the community is happening at variable rates across speakers of different ethnicities.

In the aggregate, the statistical analyses for BOAT and BOOT fronting by ethnicity and generation indicate that the diffusion of these patterns differed starkly by vowel class. We demonstrate that BOAT fronting appears to be primarily restricted to European American speakers, with both Lumbee Indian and African American speakers showing statistically undifferentiable degrees of fronting. The diffusion of this change in progress in the community of European Americans in Robeson County over apparent time appeared in the speech of the middle generation and continued into the youngest generation. In contrast, we also show that the diffusion of BOOT fronting was more widespread across speaker ethnicities: in particular, our results demonstrate that this change in progress was first taken up by European American speakers in the oldest generation and then later adopted by Lumbee Indian speakers a generation later.

Lumbee Indian speakers pattern with African American speakers for both vowel classes in the oldest generation, but then for BOOT fronting they diverge from African American speakers for the middle and youngest generations to converge with the pattern innovated by European American speakers in the oldest generation. African American speakers consistently produced the least fronted tokens in their same-aged cohorts, and they appear to be fronting less over apparent time. The Lumbee Indian speakers' convergence with European American speakers in the two most recent generations suggests dialect accommodation to the norms of European American English. How then do we explain such a trend in terms of the three communities given their relationships over time?

DISCUSSION

The different communities of Robeson County have maintained linguistic distinctiveness for generations while sharing many vocalic features of Southern English. At the same time, ethnic relations have shifted over time through contact and other sociocultural and sociopolitical circumstances,

and these may have an impact on the role of language change. In our discussion of prominent morphosyntactic features, for example, Dannenberg and Wolfram (1998, 149–50) posit that the aspectual dimension of invariant *be* has shown accommodation to the habitual meaning typically associated with AAL among younger speakers, while older speakers retain a less constrained aspectual meaning. Habitual *be* is, of course, an iconic structure of AAL, whereas the use of invariant *be* is an older feature of Lumbee English that reflects the influence of the regional varieties in contiguous regions of the Carolinas (Montgomery and Mishoe 1999).

On the other hand, the fronting of back vowels, particularly the *BOOT* vowel, shows a contrary movement in Lumbee English as it moves toward alignment with the coexistent European American vowel system and away from the AAL vowel system. There are several explanations for the current alignment pattern of Lumbee English *BOOT* fronting in terms of its accommodation of the European American vowel pattern vis-à-vis the AAL vowel system.

The relationships of Lumbee Indians to their cohort White and Black groups are both simple and complex. On the one hand, a traditionally recognized separation of three ethnic groups was represented by both formal and de facto segregation that included school systems, restrooms, different seating sections in movies, and other stringent lines of separation during the Jim Crow era. As Lowery notes (2018, 108):

The county courthouse in Lumberton included restrooms and drinking fountains for “White,” “Colored,” and “Indian.” The tobacco warehouse in Fairmont also had three separate restrooms. One of Lumberton’s movie theaters began offering segregated seating in 1931, which white residents probably saw as evidence of progress since this venue had been closed to blacks and Indians before. In theaters throughout the county, Indians and blacks sat in the balcony, which was sometimes partitioned into sections with wood or other materials to separate the groups from each other.

When we began our fieldwork in Robeson County, the primary high school where many Lumbees attended still recognized three homecoming queens and kings—White, Black, and Indian—and held other events that fostered the tripartite recognition of ethnic groups. As noted earlier, this tripartite division was at odds with the earlier census recognition, which recognized whites, free persons of color, and slaves, lumping Indians with “free persons of color.”

In the earlier context, there was Lumbee resentment toward the classification of Indians with free persons of color. As Lowery (2018, 130) summarizes, Lumbees were “‘typical Southerners’ in their attitudes toward blacks, a statement that speaks volumes about Lumbee racism and about the

way white supremacy has made racism a key feature of fitness for southern society.” Given their motivation to be unlike stigmatized African Americans and to free themselves from the earlier categorization as “free persons of color,” it would make sense for them to distinguish themselves based on a speech feature they shared with AAL. There would not be nearly as much stigma—and, in fact, some prestige—associated with adopting a feature that was formally or informally associated with the White normative model of the region. The movement away from a subtle AAL vowel trait that they once shared with African Americans would appear to fit with a kind of oppositional identity that set them apart from their historical grouping in a biracial society.

One historical incident that highlights the tenuous relationship between African Americans and Lumbees was the murder of James Jordan, the father of the famous basketball player, Michael Jordan, which took place in Robeson County during our fieldwork in the community in 1993. The two teenagers convicted of the murder were an African American and a Lumbee. As the county sheriff commented while taking a reporter to visit the then-suspects in jail:

“Anytime you look down the street and you see a black and an Indian guy, you’ve got crime. You know you’re not supposed to look at things like that, but that’s the way it is,” says [Hubert] Stone. “If they’re running together, something’s up. We always know when we spot a car and see ‘em—an Indian and a black—there’s gonna be some crime. We have to keep a firm hand on ‘em.” [Raab 1994, 79]

While such encounters speak to the racism in the county, they also provide a context in which the association of Blacks and Indians symbolically indexes antisocial behavior. In such a context, accommodating the linguistic features of a stigmatized variety of language would be counterproductive for symbolic language usage in Lumbee identification.

Coupled with the persistent anti-Black racism among both White and Indian residents in Robeson County is the ongoing, controversial status of the Lumbees’ Indian authenticity. Unlike other fully recognized American Indian tribes, there is a persistent skepticism by outsiders about the Lumbee’s status as American Indians. As investigative reporter M. Fergus Bordewich put it in *Killing the White Man’s Indian* (1996, 63), “Yet for as long as any Lumbee can remember, they have possessed an unflagging conviction that they are simply and utterly Indian, a tenacious faith that is troubled only by the failure of most other Americans to recognize it.”

In our fieldwork in Robeson County, we were routinely confronted with skepticism by some of our European American interviewees, who would express their doubts about the Lumbee’s status as authentic Indians. On several occasions, before or after our recorded interviews with European

Americans, interviewees pulled aside the second author of this article to give him some friendly, cautionary advice: that the Lumbee were not “real Indians” but a mixed group of Blacks and Whites who did not accept their status as “mixed.” This is not an uncommon theme expressed about the Lumbee, even by European Americans in Robeson County. In part, this theme is perpetuated through a number of phenotypic and cultural traits that do not match stereotypes of American Indians. For sure, there has been mixing over the centuries as Europeans and African Americans descended on North Carolina, hardly peculiar given their history of coexistence. At the same time, there has been a steadfast insistence that they are genuinely American Indian for as long as they have encountered the incursion of White and Black people into their indigenous territory, now considered their homeland. Their persistence as a distinct ethnic group has been molded in the shifting context of racial identity in the American South. As Lowery (2018, 131) notes about the central site of Pembroke, where more than 90% of the residents are Lumbee:

At its zenith as an Indian place in the 1950s, the town of Pembroke was remarkable in the otherwise biracial South. The system of Jim Crow worked so well in most places that black and white were the only racial options, yet Pembroke’s Indian residents found new ways to make the place more and more their own.

Part of their unique status as a distinct group was their use of the English language, which has remained uniquely Indian in the local context of Robeson County. In effect, it was neither White nor Black, but especially not Black. It would make sense that moving away from features associated with AAL would be a part of their subtle, oppositional identity to a stigmatized group with whom they were often mistakenly identified. As observed earlier, it is noteworthy that when they are misidentified, their mistaken identity favors them as White Southerners, not Black. The movement toward accommodating the back-vowel fronting of European Americans may be a small, nonsalient variant in this regard, but every little bit of linguistic structure helps them establish that they are not African American. In this linguistic context, it is clearly preferable to be associated with normative European American models of Southernness than the stigmatized norms of African American Language.

CONCLUSION

We have demonstrated that over three generations of speakers, there is distinct movement in the fronting of the Lumbee English *BOOT* vowel to accommodate the European American vowel model rather than the African American norm documented in their earlier use. While this vowel is relatively

nonsalient in terms of other structures of Lumbee Vernacular English studied by researchers, it is quite meaningful that this change should take place in a way that distances Lumbee English from African American Language. This finding aligns with earlier findings (Hammonds 1999) that Lumbee Vernacular English speakers misidentified by outsiders were predominantly identified as European American rather than African American speakers. It also fits with the effort of the Lumbee to escape their earlier grouping as “free persons of color” in the historical context of the biracial U.S. South. For sure, this is not the only feature to indicate their distinctiveness from African American speech, but it indicates the utility of nonsalient features in the indexing of this oppositional identity to African American Language as their dialect changes over time.

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